

ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



sure and accountability. Indian listed companies are subject to Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting requirements, and Sebi's BRSR Core has introduced assurance requirements and phased value-chain disclosures. Sustainability claims are entering the domain of data, audit and assurance.

Markets and capital are also becoming stricter. Exporters and companies in global value chains will face sharper questions. ESG

has seen hype and backlash, but the investor question remains valid: is a company managing long-term risks, or merely its image?

So how does corporate India move from gimmick to reality?

First, be precise. Broad claims must give way to specific statements—like “made with 80% recycled aluminium”, “uses 35% less water than our 2020 baseline”, or “powered by renewable electricity for 60% of manufacturing operations.”

Second, build evidence. Every claim must have a file behind it: scientific basis, lifecycle assessment where relevant, independent certification, internal measurement, supplier documentation and audit trail.

Third, practise proportionality. A firm should not project the whole brand as sustainable because one product line or input has improved. If only the packaging is recyclable, say so. If carbon neutrality depends on offsets, disclose that clearly.

Fourth, make sustainability a board issue. Boards should ask: what are our top environmental risks, who verifies progress, and are we rewarding actual improvements?

Finally, show humility. Not every firm can become green overnight, especially in sectors like steel, cement, aviation, chemicals, textiles and logistics. But consumers and investors respect an honest transition plan.

India has a particular opportunity. As a fast-growing economy, our approach must combine ambition with pragmatism: encourage innovation, avoid excessive compliance burden for smaller firms, but act firmly against deception.

The goal is not to frighten companies. Greenhushing—where firms stop talking about sustainability for fear of scrutiny—is not desirable. Instead, the goal is truthful communication. Regulators should punish deception, not experimentation. Industry bodies should create common standards. Consumers should ask better questions. Investors should reward measurable progress.

Greenwashing will end when the market, regulator and consumer reward authenticity.

The green leaf on the package will still matter. But only when there is real green work behind it. **BT**

Views are personal